UVA ENGINEERING

IMPACT REPORT 2026

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A Letter From
DEAN JENNIFER WEST

Engineering for the Greater Good is more than our mission — it is a promise to build a brighter future by making lives healthier, safer and more connected, keeping people at the heart of all we do.

This year tested that promise. Shifts in federal funding cast a shadow of uncertainty over research universities, including ours. Our faculty met the moment with creativity and resilience, submitting a record-breaking 686 research proposals.

That same spirit of optimism shines through our students. Our MARS space robotics experiential learning team won NASA’s 2026 Lunabotics competition and is heading to the international championship. Students in the Dean’s Undergraduate Research Fellows program are pursuing research with faculty mentors. VentureForward program micro-grants are helping student founders turn ideas into companies — including Cambrient AI, UVA’s 2026 Entrepreneurship Cup winner.

Through it all, our community’s support has been a steady light. Last year, more than 4,000 donors rose to the occasion, giving $27.4 million to support priorities including student enrichment and opportunity, experiential learning and entrepreneurship, research and impact, and infrastructure — thank you.

We continue to imagine the future for the Whitehead Road Engineering Academic Building, where new ideas in AI, health, energy and the environment will come to life. Generous gifts have brought this project within reach, but our work to realize its vision is not yet done.

As I begin my second term, I invite you to join us as we keep people at the heart of Engineering for the Greater Good. The future is bright, and I look forward to all that lies ahead.

JENNIFER L. WEST, PH.D.
DEAN, SCHOOL OF ENGINEERING AND APPLIED SCIENCE
SAUNDERS FAMILY PROFESSOR OF ENGINEERING

At UVA ENGINEERING *we are* BUILDING A BRIGHTER FUTURE *through* ENGINEERING *for the* GREATER GOOD

Our mission is to make the world a better place through bold research and world-class education, putting people at the center of innovation.

Our vibrant community attracts outstanding students and faculty from around the world to our internationally recognized education and research programs, where we are making groundbreaking discoveries in fields including artificial intelligence, hypersonics, cancer research, and more.

UVA Engineering is part of the top-ranked University of Virginia and is distinguished by a community of care where collegiality, support, entrepreneurial thinking, and engineering ethics thrive.

Concrete Canoe Team

UVA ENGINEERING by the NUMBERS

4,534
Students

268
Faculty Members

$84M
Annual Research Expenditures

ENGINEERING *for the* GREATER GOOD

STRATEGIC PRIORITIES

EXPANDING HANDS-ON LEARNING OPPORTUNITIES

- **Undergraduate Research:** The Dean's Undergraduate Research Fellows program paired student researchers with faculty mentors, Anisha Jarang was named a Goldwater Scholar for research excellence, and a newly approved research minor will give students an academic credential in scholarly research.
- **Experiential Learning:** The MARS space robotics team won the Artemis Grand Prize at NASA's 2026 Lunabotics championship and will compete internationally. The Cyber Defense team beat Claude and collegiate rivals for a No. 2 national ranking.
- **Industry Partnerships:** Internships and real-world learning are translating into jobs. B.S. graduates averaged $97,000 in starting salaries at employers including AWS, Capital One, Deloitte, Merck, Rolls-Royce and SpaceX.

ADVANCING RESEARCH

- **Research Grants:** The school submitted a record-breaking 686 research proposals in fiscal year 2026 and won 16 awards of $1 million or greater from funders including the NSF, NIH, Department of Defense, Department of Energy, NASA and NOAA. Industry funding of faculty research also hit record levels.
- **Research Leadership:** Liqin Ke received a $3 million ARPA-E award to discover permanent magnets that improve energy productivity. Devin Harris shared civil infrastructure expertise in India as a Fulbright Specialist. Ferdinando Fioretto is applying AI to power grids for the Genesis Mission. Nikos Sidiropoulos won a top IEEE signal processing honor. The New York Times Magazine featured biomedical start-up Springbok Analytics.

FOSTERING ENTREPRENEURSHIP

- **Faculty Entrepreneurs:** Bryan Berger was named UVA's Innovator of the Year for his company Lytos Technologies, reflecting faculty policy changes that have fueled a highly progressive entrepreneurial environment.
- **Student Entrepreneurs:** The VentureForward program provided microgrants to student founders, including Cambrient AI — winner of UVA's 2026 Entrepreneurship Cup.

IMPROVING INFRASTRUCTURE AND EXPANDING SPACE

- **Whitehead Road Engineering Academic Building:** Significant gifts are driving momentum for this critical priority. The state has funded architectural design, and the philanthropy target is in reach with continued support.
- **First-Year Engineering Center:** Thornton Hall renovations are underway to create a new home for the center on Engineer's Way.

UNDERGRADUATE EDUCATION

UVA Engineering undergraduate students are poised to become leaders in their fields, combining engineering expertise with leadership experiences, communication skills, and a foundation of engineering ethics.

BY THE NUMBERS

13,666
Number of Applicants

725
First-Year Students

130
New Transfer Students

$97K
Average Starting Salary for B.S. Graduates

3,102
Undergraduates, Bachelor of Science

414
Undergraduates, Computer Science Bachelor of Arts

97%
Graduation Rate

UVA ENGINEERING MAJORS

AEROSPACE ENGINEERING • BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING • CHEMICAL ENGINEERING
CIVIL ENGINEERING • COMPUTER ENGINEERING • COMPUTER SCIENCE • ELECTRICAL ENGINEERING
MATERIALS SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING • MECHANICAL ENGINEERING • SYSTEMS ENGINEERING

THE FIRST-YEAR ENGINEERING CENTER

UVA Engineering established the First-Year Engineering Center on a premise: the first year of undergraduate education must build more than skill. The FYEC gives students a common foundation — technical know-how, a focus on ethics, career exploration, strong relationships with professors who both teach and advise — and helps them see themselves as engineers.

"We emphasize developing students' sense of engineering identity alongside their technical skills," said Leyf Starling, the center's director. "Students thrive when they see themselves as engineers and are part of a supportive community."

The FYEC experience underpins UVA Engineering's 97 percent undergraduate program graduation rate.

Six faculty lead more than 700 first-year students through two semesters of Engineering Foundations courses: fall semester teams solve a problem on UVA Grounds while learning MATLAB, CAD and 3D printing; spring teams work with a real client.

"The Center helped me develop my identity while solving a real engineering problem," said fourth-year systems engineering major Will Keenan. "My Engineering Foundations team designed a space-saving bike rack for UVA Sustainability to encourage students to use sustainable transportation." Keenan has taken what he learned from his FYEC experience into roles as a teaching assistant, undergraduate researcher, conference presenter, and member of UVA Residence Staff.

By combining a focus on mindset and identity with engineering skills, ethics education, career preparation, and strong relationships, UVA Engineering is creating the next generation of engineering leaders. Thornton Hall renovations are also underway to create a new home for the center on Engineer's Way. ■

2026 DEAN'S UNDERGRADUATE RESEARCH FELLOWS

This summer, 29 UVA Engineering students served as 2026 Dean's Undergraduate Research Fellows, pursuing hands-on discovery in faculty labs. The program funds immersive summer research paired with weekly professional development and community-building events.

"The Dean's Fellows represent some of the very best of UVA Engineering," said Lakeshia Taite, assistant professor of chemical engineering, who leads the program. "They are accomplished scholars, thoughtful leaders and engaged members of our community who will help shape the experience of their fellow students."

Faculty mentors describe the Fellows program as a transformative experience that accelerates students' confidence and independence in the lab. Students consistently report that the program helps them clarify academic interests, strengthen graduate school applications, and envision future careers in research, industry, and beyond.

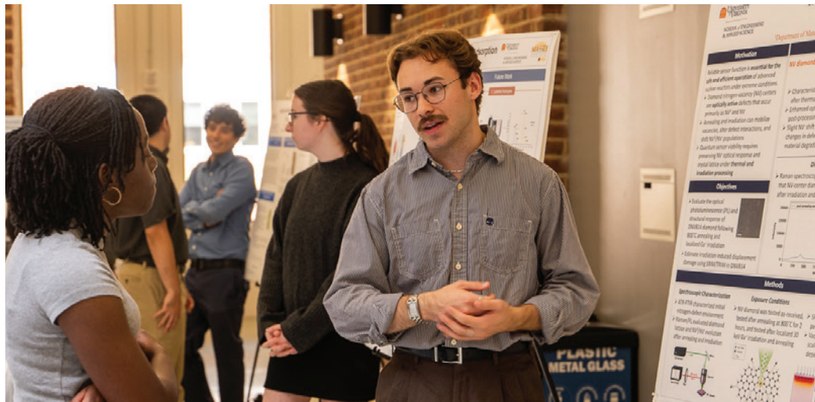
Third-year biomedical engineering student and Dean's Fellow Zoe Bastardi spent her summer working in the labs of faculty mentors Steven Caliari and Donald Griffin. Her biomaterials research sought to better understand musculoskeletal injury and ultimately provide better treatment options.

Beyond the technical skills, Bastardi also said the experience taught her lessons that will extend well beyond the lab.

"One of the biggest lessons I learned is how important it is to be adaptable," she said. "You can have a schedule and do the procedure right, but sometimes the cells just don't want to grow. There are many things outside of your control, and you have to learn to keep going when the process doesn't go as planned."

Bastardi will continue the project during the school year and will present her research at the Biomedical Engineering Society's annual meeting. A newly approved research minor will also be available to undergraduate students this year, giving them opportunities not only to pursue research but also to earn an innovative academic credential. ■

They are accomplished scholars, thoughtful leaders and engaged members of our community who will help shape the experience of their fellow students."



UNDERGRADUATE STUDENTS

Class of 2026

ZACHARY PALAZZOTTO

MAJOR: Biomedical Engineering

Biomedical engineer Zachary Palazzotto loves UVA Engineering's small-school feel combined with the resources of a large state university. Proximity to the health sciences ensured a clinical focus in his biomedical engineering classes. After graduation, Palazzotto will join Merck's Manufacturing Leadership Development Program, where he will rotate to a new domestic or international pharmaceutical manufacturing site each year for three years.

SELECTED AWARDS AND ACTIVITIES

Engineering Student Council President; UVA Engineering Outstanding Student Award; Lawn Resident; Gray-Carrington Scholarship; Alpha Epsilon Pi; Inter-Fraternity Council.

IN THEIR OWN WORDS

"Engineering for the greater good means understanding that we are real human beings with values, goals and ethically framed decisions. We are not machines carrying out aimless tasks. At UVA Engineering, I have been taught that society will shape the technology I build, and the technology I build will shape society. This is a huge responsibility that I don't take lightly." ■

ANNE MARIE BRANCH

MAJOR: Aerospace Engineering

Anne Marie Branch wanted to build rockets, and at UVA Engineering she did just that. Under Branch's leadership, the UVA Rocketry team earned honors at the 2026 International Rocket Engineering Competition in Texas. A favorite memory of her UVA Engineering experience was watching the Artemis II launch from Lacy Hall with her teammates and friends. After graduation, she will work as a mechanical engineer for the Naval Sea Systems Command at the Naval Surface Warfare Center Dahlgren Division.

SELECTED AWARDS AND ACTIVITIES

UVA Rocketry Team President; Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering Capstone Lab Teaching Assistant; Undergraduate Research Assistant; Student Bus Driver.

IN THEIR OWN WORDS

"Under the mentorship of professors and former team leads, I have grown into the role of UVA Rocketry Team president. I've learned how to structure an engineering project from start to finish and manage complex sub-teams. It has been incredibly fulfilling to watch my teammates develop as engineers too." ■

KATIE FIDLER

MAJOR: Systems Engineering

Katie Fidler tackles climate policy from an engineer's perspective. Through UVA Engineering's Policy Internship Program, she worked in the White House and with NASA on environmental policy. Fidler founded the student-led club BAPS — Become a Problem-Solver — which helps UVA service organizations tackle operational challenges using a systems engineering framework. After graduation, she will enter the Massachusetts Institute of Technology to pursue an M.S. in Technology and Policy.

SELECTED AWARDS AND ACTIVITIES

Jefferson Scholar; Rodman Scholar; National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship; UVA Study Abroad Programs (Dominica, Argentina); Intramural Sports (Beach Volleyball, Flag Football), Pi Beta Phi.

IN THEIR OWN WORDS

"I chose UVA Engineering because I wanted to learn practical skills to help me solve problems for others. I've learned how to better communicate technical information to non-technical audiences and hope to ultimately advance efficiency across larger systems." ■

TARAN GUPTA

MAJOR: Civil Engineering

Taran Gupta's first time on Grounds was as a high schooler at UVA Band Day, so it's no surprise the Cavalier Marching Band has become a huge part of his UVA experience. Despite a busy schedule as drum major, Gupta worked as a UVA Engineering teaching assistant and as a member of the Steel Bridge Capstone Team. After graduation, he will spend a summer as a civil field engineer with Mortenson Construction and then enter the UVAccelerate program to earn his master's degree in civil engineering.

SELECTED AWARDS AND ACTIVITIES

Cavalier Marching Band Drum Major; UVA Athletic Band, Concert Band and Wind Ensemble; UVA Engineering Outstanding Student Award; Steel Bridge Capstone Team; Civil Engineering Teaching Assistant.

IN THEIR OWN WORDS

"Making music has pushed me creatively — an essential skill for engineering. As drum major, you shape the experience of every marching band member and it has been incredibly fulfilling to see them grow. It reminds me why I choose to wake up every day and work toward creating (engineering) a better world." ■

STUDENT EXPERIENCE

UVA Engineering is student-centered, invested in each student's success and well-being. The school is committed to creating a community of care and supports its students at every step of their academic journey.

Rocketry Team

EXPERIENTIAL LEARNING

Experiential learning opportunities allow students to participate in hands-on design, build, and competition teams that span multiple engineering disciplines and give them real-world experience in applying knowledge to solve problems. Examples include:

Cavalier Autonomous Racing (CAVCAR)

An internationally recognized autonomous racing team that creates high-speed, AI-powered self-driving race cars using LiDAR, machine learning, and sensor fusion algorithms. The team won the Indy Autonomous Challenge and set a world record for autonomous racing in 2024.

Concrete Canoe Team

The UVA Concrete Canoe Team is a civil engineering design team that competes in the annual American Society of Civil Engineers Symposium. Every year, the team designs and builds a canoe made entirely out of concrete. Members are able to earn credit, apply knowledge learned in classes, and build relationships with peers in engineering.

Cyber Defense Team

A cybersecurity team that protects simulated networks against cyberattacks in competition. The team is ranked No. 2 in the country and has won back-to-back second place finishes in the National Collegiate Cyber Defense Competition.

Mechatronics and Robotics Society (MARS)

A space robotics team that develops lunar excavation and construction robots for NASA's annual Lunabotics competition. Their robot "Bruno" competed at Kennedy Space Center and earned them six awards overall including the competition's top honor, the Artemis Grand Prize.

Rocketry Team

A rocketry team that designs, builds, and launches rockets for the International Rocket Engineering Competition (IREC). In 2026, the team earned first place for its launch livestream and second place for its technical report.

Virginia Motorsports

A motorsports team that designs, builds, and races cars. Lacy Hall is the headquarters for all Virginia Motorsports operations and the team holds an annual Motorsports weekend each spring.

SUMMER BRIDGE PROGRAM

The Summer Bridge Program is a multi-week residential experience that helps incoming first-year students successfully transition to college life. Since the 1980s, the Bridge Program has provided students with a sense of community, orientation to university resources and intensive academic preparation — including a three-credit mathematics course designed to help them succeed in the engineering calculus sequence.

CAREER DEVELOPMENT

The Center for Engineering Career Development prepares students to make smart, strategic career decisions throughout their professional lives. In recent years, UVA Engineering has integrated career development instruction into first-year engineering education via the First-Year Engineering Center. New Director Lindsay Schiller joined CECD in summer 2026 and will lead the continued evolution of this work by embedding career learning and professional preparation into the third year of the undergraduate program.

CAPSTONE PROJECTS

Capstone design projects represent the culmination of undergraduate education training, with team-based projects that allow students to apply technical knowledge and professional skills to real-world engineering challenges. Through a structured design process – from identifying needs to delivering tested solutions – students demonstrate their abilities in engineering, communication, collaboration and teamwork.

SCHOLARS PROGRAMS

UVA Clark Scholars

Since 2018 the **UVA Clark Scholars Program** has supported undergraduate engineering students with high leadership potential and demonstrated financial need. This year, UVA Engineering and the A. James and Alice B. Clark Foundation announced an $11 million gift to support UVA's Clark Scholars Program and provide tuition assistance for veterans, fund student community impact initiatives, support the planned Whitehead Road Engineering Academic Building project, and provide enrichment programs for transfer students. In summer 2026, UVA Engineering launched STEP, the Summer Transfer Engineering Program, to smooth transfer students' transition to UVA Engineering and set them up for success.

The Rodman Scholars Program is an honors program for the top five percent of each incoming class of Engineering undergraduate students. It provides scholarships, specialized courses, and priority course enrollment as well as a strong community of Rodman students and alumni.

GLOBAL EXPERIENCES

UVA Engineering's global experiences help students develop new perspectives and cross-cultural competencies essential for engineering leadership. Students can choose from semester-long, summer or January (J-term) offerings that meet their needs.

Students can also participate in engineering consulting projects abroad, including popular opportunities in Argentina, Sweden, and Germany. The UVA in Valencia program has served UVA students for more than 40 years. It is the biggest study abroad program for UVA Engineering students and allows them to earn UVA course credit.

ENGINEERING ETHICS

UVA Engineering embeds ethics into the curriculum. Its Science, Technology and Society (STS) program is the only one in the U.S. housed within an engineering school. It offers a required Engineering Ethics course and programming through its Engineering Character Strength Initiative.

The Moments of Strength speaker series inspires students by bringing engineering leaders to UVA whose personal stories demonstrate how strong character has helped them live with integrity during challenging moments in their professional lives.

THE CENTER FOR CONNECTION IN ENGINEERING (THE CONNECT)

The Connect is UVA Engineering's hub for student belonging, support, and community-focused programming. It is a warm, affirming environment that links students to resources, offers study space, and hosts student organizations and events. The Connect supports programs like Summer Bridge and Clark Scholars, serving students, faculty and staff, alumni, future engineers, and the broader community. The Connect helps students to strengthen their identities as engineers, to succeed academically and beyond, and to create connections to the Engineering school, UVA, and each other.

UVA Engineering's MARS TEAM Wins NASA 2026 Lunabotics Championship

The Mechatronics and Robotics Society, otherwise known as UVA Engineering's MARS team, won top honors at NASA's 2026 Lunabotics Challenge, an annual competition in which university teams design robots to perform construction tasks on the lunar surface.

Competing against teams from around the country, the student-run UVA Engineering space robotics team captured the championship and Artemis Grand Prize after a dramatic comeback: despite losing a wheel during its first run, students kept the robot running and secured the overall title.

The competition, part of NASA's Artemis-era lunar preparations, requires autonomous or remotely operated robots to excavate and transport simulated lunar soil, known as regolith, while applying NASA systems engineering principles.

The team earned six awards: second place in construction, autonomy and systems engineering; the Innovation Award; a special recognition for mission excellence; and the Artemis Grand Prize.

> **They reimagined NASA's bucket drum design as a curved helix, a concept so difficult to manufacture that we had never pursued it ourselves.**
>
> —Robert Mueller
>
> NASA Senior Technologist and Lunabotics Challenge Co-founder

For months, students spent late nights machining parts, testing excavation systems and refining software for their robot, nicknamed "Bruno." Its rotating drum excavation system kept the design simple and reliable, and Bruno helped build one of the event's largest berms — compacted, raised areas that serve as barriers, paths or foundations.

"They reimagined NASA's bucket drum design as a curved helix, a concept so difficult to manufacture that we had never pursued it ourselves," said Robert Mueller, NASA senior technologist and Lunabotics Challenge co-founder. "A wheel broke during competition, yet they kept going and competed with only three wheels, demonstrating just how robust their design was."

Because MARS is entirely student-run, students lead every phase, from CAD modeling to fabrication, autonomous controls and field testing — applying classroom knowledge to a real-world challenge while building leadership and teamwork skills.

For UVA Engineering's MARS team, the championship caps months of work and marks the start of preparations for the next mission — which in this case is an invitation to the fall 2026 international Lunabotics competition.

GRADUATE EDUCATION

Graduate students make up more than 20 percent of the Engineering student community. UVA Engineering's graduate education program offers excellence in academics and research, strong mentorship and a supportive community.

GRADUATE EDUCATION PROGRAMS

UVA Engineering offers doctoral, master of science and master of engineering programs across nine engineering disciplines.

Doctoral (Ph.D.) programs, which represent the highest level of academic achievement in engineering, focus extensively on original research and are funded primarily through research assistantships, teaching assistantships, and fellowships.

Ph.D. matriculation yield is more than 50 percent. Fellowships play a critical role in attracting top talent.

Master of Science (M.S.) programs combine coursework with a research component.

Master of Engineering (M.E.) programs focus on advanced coursework, often attracting students who want to advance their careers and increase their job market competitiveness.

The UVAccelerate program also provides a streamlined pathway for UVA undergraduate students to earn a master of engineering degree and increase their earning potential. Applicants with a cumulative GPA of 3.4 or higher at the time they apply are guaranteed admission to the M.E. program in their undergraduate major.

BY THE NUMBERS

1,018
Graduate Students

695
Ph.D. Students

100
New Ph.D. Students

5.5
Average Years to Graduation for Ph.D. Students

323
Master's Students

178
New Master's Students

119
UVAccelerate Master's Students admitted for Fall 2027

2026 NSF GRADUATE RESEARCH FELLOWSHIPS

In 2026, UVA Engineering had 22 scholars who received prestigious National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship Program (GRFP) awards, which honor outstanding graduate students in STEM disciplines.

THOMAS M. ACKLESON
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

JOSHUA KURIAN ALEXANDER
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

ANDREW BALCH
COMPUTER SCIENCE

EMILY BUBONOVICH
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

EMILY CHANG
COMPUTER SCIENCE

EIRIAN CROCKER
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

QUINN EARLY
MECHANICAL ENGINEERING

KATIE L. FIDLER
SYSTEMS ENGINEERING

ALAINA GORDON
SYSTEMS ENGINEERING

HAO GU
COMPUTER SCIENCE

GRACE HARDY
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

EVELYN HERGENHAN
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

JOONHYUK KO
COMPUTER SCIENCE

THEODORE LENGKONG
AEROSPACE ENGINEERING

OWEN MCKENNEY
MECHANICAL ENGINEERING

DELANEY MCNALLY
CHEMICAL ENGINEERING

GAVIN G. MILLER
AEROSPACE ENGINEERING

SEAN MICHAEL ROBINSON
CHEMICAL ENGINEERING

WAMIA SAID
COMPUTER SCIENCE

KATRINA SAMETH
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

ALEXANDER R. SCHAEFER
COMPUTER ENGINEERING

MIRIAM E. STEVENS
BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING

UVAccelerate

Gives Engineering Students Fast Track to a Master's Degree

UVA Engineering undergraduates now have a fast track to career success through UVAccelerate, a program that lets students earn both a bachelor's and a master's degree in as little as five years.

"UVAccelerate is a focused, streamlined pathway to a Master of Engineering degree that saves students both time and money," said Matthew B. Panzer, Associate Dean for Graduate Education and Post-Doctoral Affairs.

Students apply in their third year and begin graduate coursework in their fourth, typically finishing both a B.S. and an M.E. in five years or less rather than six or more. Applicants with a cumulative GPA of 3.4 or higher at the time they apply are guaranteed admission to the M.E. program in their undergraduate major. The program launched in 2022 and has steadily grown, with 66 students enrolled for fall 2026 and 119 admitted for fall 2027.

"I decided to apply to UVAccelerate in my third year since it was a no-cost, frictionless way to apply to a graduate engineering program at an institution I already loved and knew was reputable," said UVAccelerate student Taran Gupta, who received his B.S. in civil engineering in 2026. Gupta is now pursuing his M.E. degree and expanding his undergraduate knowledge with more focused coursework in structural engineering.

The degree is entirely coursework-based — no thesis required — and is taught by UVA Engineering's tenured and tenure-track faculty. It embodies the school's "Support and Succeed" model: engineering-centered career advising, whole-student wellness resources, and a dedicated faculty advisor for each program. Advising starts before students enroll, helping them use AP credits to map the fastest path to a degree.

Through conversations with faculty and advisors, I saw how a master's degree could help me develop the technical skills needed to help me build a career in the space industry after graduation," said Yatzil Romero Rodriguez, who received her B.S. in electrical engineering in 2026 and is now completing her M.E. degree through the UVAccelerate program.

UVAccelerate options are available in biomedical, chemical, civil, computer, electrical, materials science, mechanical and aerospace, and systems engineering, as well as computer science; some courses are offered online. UVA Engineering bachelor of science candidates, UVA bachelor of arts in computer science candidates, and Sweet Briar College engineering science candidates are eligible.

The payoff can be substantial. Engineering graduates who enter the workforce with a graduate degree earn more in their first job than the national average for STEM bachelor's recipients.

Some students can gain benefits beyond salary as well. For Gupta, UVAccelerate gives him specialized knowledge as well as a year of experience that he can apply toward his goal of earning a Professional Engineer (PE) license. "Because I want to specialize in construction and structural engineering, this coursework provides the opportunity to go deeper in structural engineering principles. It gives me experience and knowledge that my peers may not have, helping me carve out a unique niche. This will be important not only as a I eventually transition out of construction into design, but also for my path to a PE license." ■

ENGINEERING *for the* GREATER GOOD

GRADUATE STUDENTS *class of* 2026

DEBASHISH SUR

DEGREE: Ph.D., Materials Science and Engineering

DESIGNING METAL ALLOYS THAT PROTECT THE INFRASTRUCTURE PEOPLE DEPEND ON

Debashish Sur studies corrosion, the slow breakdown of metal that drives some of the most expensive and dangerous failures in infrastructure like ships, pipelines and power equipment.

He designs new alloys — blends of five or more metals, rather than the usual one or two — that resist corrosion better than stainless steel while staying lighter and stronger.

As a Ph.D. student in the Department of Materials Science and Engineering, Sur worked with Professor John Scully on research funded by the Office of Naval Research, since corrosion threatens ships that spend years in salt water. Having lightweight, resistant alloys could mean fewer repairs and safer equipment.

At UVA Engineering, Sur contributed to 19 peer-reviewed articles and was one of three researchers worldwide invited to present at the prestigious Gordon Research Seminar.

He also taught an introduction to materials science course, mentored undergraduate researchers and served as a local science fair judge.

Sur won UVA Engineering's 2026 Outstanding Ph.D. Student Award, helped organize the University of Virginia Engineering Research Symposium (UVERS) and is a member of the Raven Society. ■

LAUREN HORDE

DEGREE: Ph.D., Systems Engineering

DISCOVERING WHAT MAKES YOUR PHONE'S BUZZ EASIER TO NOTICE

Human perception researcher Lauren Horde studies a familiar moment: your phone buzzes and you either miss it or notice too late. That's at the center of her haptics research — the gap between what a device signals and what a person perceives, and how to close that gap.

As a Ph.D. student in the Department of Systems and Information Engineering, Horde built expertise in human factors. She and Associate Professor Sara Riggs studied how people perceive vibration changes — whether they noticed a shift in a vibration's location faster, like a buzz moving from one finger to another, or whether a vibration that grows stronger or changes rhythm is noticed more quickly. Horde found that changes in strength or pattern were detected faster, which others have applied to guide drivers' attention or help devices like smartphones communicate through vibration.

As a Ph.D. student, Horde mentored undergraduate Mitra Tafreshi on a brain wave research project, an opportunity that showcased what she sees as UVA Engineering's rare balance of academic and research excellence alongside a culture of warmth and community.

Horde received a National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship and the Ruthie Oxford Memorial Award. ■

SOUMEE GUHA

DEGREE: Ph.D., Computer Engineering

USING ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE TO CATCH WHAT MEDICAL SCANS MAY MISS

A love of circuits, mathematics and the sheer joy of discovery drew Soumee Guha to computer engineering, but it's the impact on people that keeps her there.

Ultrasounds are the first photographs many parents have of their children, but their grainy in utero images can make it difficult to diagnose fetal issues. The same may be true of diagnostic images of a person's heart or liver. Guha's research aims to fix that.

As a Ph.D. student in the Charles L. Brown Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering and the Virginia Image and Video Analysis (VIVA) lab, Guha built diffusion models — mathematical tools that generate new, clearer images from distorted originals — to sharpen medical images of organs like the heart, liver and uterus. These images help doctors catch issues that may affect a person's heart function, lead to liver disease or harm a developing fetus.

Scott Acton, the American Telephone and Telegraph Company Professor of Engineering and department chair who leads VIVA, sees Guha's approach as first-of-its-kind. "Soumee is building solutions as part of a unified framework that will move the field forward," Acton said.

Guha received the Carlos and Esther Farrar Fellowship and served as president of the Graduate Engineering Student Council. ■

ALEC MENZER

DEGREE: Ph.D., Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering

APPLYING FISH SCHOOLING INSIGHTS TO BUILD MORE EFFICIENT UNDERWATER ROBOTS

Before he studied computational fluid dynamics, Alec Menzer was a competitive swimmer. Racing freestyle and butterfly gave him a firsthand perspective on efficient movement through water, one that followed him into his Ph.D. research.

As a Ph.D. student in the Department of Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering, Menzer used computer simulations with Professor Haibo Dong to show that a school of 10 fish swims more efficiently than a single fish by riding others' turbulence — a finding that could lead to the development of efficient groups of underwater robots to support costly, dangerous tasks like inspecting underwater cables or monitoring ocean quality.

At UVA Engineering, Menzer excelled as both a researcher and a teacher, earning a graduate teaching fellowship and praise for the computational methods course he taught to over 100 students.

"His mentorship is hands-on and impactful, reflecting both technical expertise and a genuine investment in developing others," Dong said.

Menzer received a National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship, the Carlos and Esther Farrar Fellowship and the 2026 Outstanding Graduate Researcher Award from the Department of Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering. ■

FACULTY AND RESEARCH

UVA Engineering is powered by exceptional faculty whose expertise drives breakthrough discoveries and shapes the next generation of engineering leaders.

BY THE NUMBERS

268 Total Faculty

- **192** Tenured and Tenure-Track Faculty
- **4** 2026 NSF CAREER Award Winners
- **9** NAE Members
- **14** NAI Members
- **686** FY26 Research Proposals
- **$84M** FY26 Research Expenditures

UVA ENGINEERING'S FACULTY BUILD A BRIGHTER FUTURE

UVA Engineering has created a dynamic environment where world-class researchers tackle society's most pressing challenges. The school's faculty includes tenured and tenure-track (T3) faculty researchers and educators, as well as academic general faculty who focus exclusively on teaching—all of whom elevate the student experience.

The school's commitment to faculty excellence is reflected not only in the caliber of researchers and educators it attracts, but also in the comprehensive support systems that enable their success—from strategic internal funding and grant development programs to research communities that spark interdisciplinary collaboration. This integrated approach has yielded remarkable results: faculty recognition at the highest national levels, strong research momentum, and innovations that translate from laboratory breakthroughs to real-world impact.

Yen-Ling Kuo, Computer Science

TOP 25 UVA SPONSORED FUNDING RECIPIENTS

Seven engineering faculty were among the top 25 UVA research funding leaders for fiscal year 2025:

MATHEWS JACOB · **ARTHUR W. LICHTENBERGER** · **NATASHA SHEYBANI** · **XU YI** · **KEVIN JANES** · **JEFFREY SAUCERMAN** · **HAYDN WADLEY**

WELCOMING NEW CHAIRS

Alfredo Garcia, Professor and Chair, Department of Systems and Information Engineering

ALFREDO GARCIA, a leading expert in operations research and AI-enabled systems engineering, has returned to UVA to lead the Department of Systems and Information Engineering, which celebrates its 50th anniversary this year. Garcia was a member of UVA Engineering's faculty from 2001 to 2015 and most recently held the Michael and Sugar Barnes Professorship at Texas A&M University.

"Systems engineering is becoming even more important as artificial intelligence transforms industrial organizations," Garcia said. "I am excited to return to UVA and work with the department's faculty, staff and students to build a distinctive vision for human-centered, AI-enabled systems engineering."

Garcia's research lies at the intersection of systems engineering, artificial intelligence, optimization, control and human decision-making. His work has addressed intelligent and autonomous systems, reinforcement learning, human-AI interaction, distributed optimization, multi-agent systems and the operation and regulation of energy markets. His current research focuses on reliable, adaptive and human-centered AI systems that can reason about human behavior, uncertainty and latent cognitive states.

Garcia earned his Ph.D. and master's degree in industrial and operations engineering from the University of Michigan. He also holds an engineering degree from Universidad de los Andes in Colombia and completed graduate studies in automatic control and industrial computing at Université de Toulouse III in France.

Garcia's priorities as chair include fostering interdisciplinary research, developing new academic programs and preparing students to design, analyze and manage complex systems in which people and intelligent technologies increasingly work together. ■

Jonathan Beever, Professor and Chair, Department of Engineering and Society

The University of Virginia School of Engineering and Applied Science has announced the appointment of **JONATHAN BEEVER** as the new chair of the Department of Engineering and Society.

Beever joins UVA Engineering from the University of Central Florida, where he served as professor of philosophy and director of the Center for Ethics. An internationally recognized scholar in engineering ethics, artificial intelligence ethics and responsible innovation, his research focuses on helping engineers and technology leaders navigate the ethical challenges posed by emerging technologies.

Beever said a shared belief in what it means to build good engineers drew him to UVA. "Building good engineers is about more than just technical training," he said, noting that ethics is foundational to that broader mission.

He is a past chair of the American Society for Engineering Education's engineering ethics committee. Beever also serves on the editorial board of the Online Ethics Center, a national resource led by UVA, through which he has built many relationships in the field over the years.

Beever received his bachelor's degree in philosophy from the University of Maine and Ph.D. from Purdue.

Beever's priorities as chair include creating an environment in which faculty can continually evolve the curriculum and increase their research and collaborations within the department and across UVA Engineering. ■

FACULTY ACCOLADES

UVA UNIVERSITY-WIDE AWARDS

UVA RESEARCH ACHIEVEMENT AWARDS

Seven UVA Engineering researchers were honored by the Office of the Vice President for Research.

PATRICK HOPKINS
Distinguished Researcher Award

ZONGLI LIN
Distinguished Researcher Award

XU YI
Research Excellence Award

HILARY BART-SMITH, HAIBO DONG AND DANIEL QUINN
Research Collaboration Award

JASON PAPIN
Research Mentor Award

SHANNON CENTER FELLOWS

The Office of the Provost awards this three-year fellowship to outstanding mid-career faculty.

HAIBO DONG
Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering

JON IHLEFELD
Materials Science and Engineering, Electrical and Computer Engineering

TEACHING EXCELLENCE

MARK FLORYAN
All-University Teaching Award

ROB KELLY
Jefferson Scholars Foundation Hartfield Excellence in Teaching Award

ROBBIE HOTT
Jefferson Scholars Foundation Hartfield Excellence in Teaching Award

HONORS AND ACCOLADES

HOMA ALEMZADEH
DSN Test of Time Award

ANDREAS BELING
Optica Fellow

CAMILLE BILODEAU
ICheme Senior Moulton Medal

LIHENG CAI
American Physical Society John H. Dillon Medal

MATTHEW DWYER
ACM SIGSOFT Academy

SEBASTIAN ELBAUM
ACM SIGSOFT Academy

JERRY FLORO
Materials Research Society Impact Award

GEOFF GEISE
North American Membrane Society Permeance Prize

AYMAN KARIM
American Chemical Society Lectureship for the Advancement of Catalytic Science in Heterogeneous Catalysis

YEN-LING KUO
Women in Robotics and Automation Early Career Award

JIM LAMBERT
Society for Risk Analysis 2025 Richard J. Burk Outstanding Service Award

JUNDONG LI
International Conference on Data Mining Tao Li Award

ZONGLI LIN
Fellow, American Society of Mechanical Engineers

CHANG LOU
ACM Rising Star Faculty Award

CRAIG MEYER
International Society for Magnetic Resonance in Medicine Gold Medal

JOHN SCULLY
Fellow, Minerals, Metals and Materials Society

Southeastern Universities Research Association Distinguished Scientist Award

MARK SHERRIFF
ACM Teacher of the Year Award

NATASHA SHEYBANI
Southeastern Universities Research Association Early Career Scientist Award

NIKOLAOS SIDIROPOULOS
IEEE Fourier Award

RUPA VALDEZ
Fellow, Human Factors and Ergonomics Society

ANIL VULLIKANTI
2025 ACM SIGKDD Applied Data Science Test of Time Award

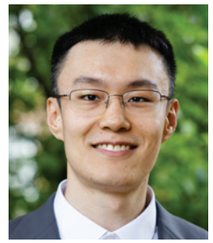
JING YANG
Fellow, IEEE

2026 NSF CAREER AWARD WINNERS

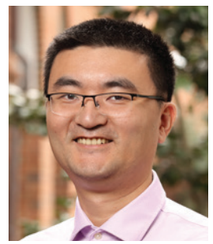
Four early-career faculty at the University of Virginia School of Engineering and Applied Science have earned National Science Foundation CAREER Awards — one of the highest honors for young faculty in science and engineering.

JASON BATES
Assistant Professor, Chemical Engineering
Energy and Environment: Creating Opportunity From Nitrate Pollution
Bates is investigating how to convert nitrate from fertilizer runoff into valuable chemical products with renewably sourced electricity. His project could improve nitrate conversion, leading to new water treatment technologies.

CHEN CHEN
Assistant Professor, Computer Science
AI for Public Health: Building Next-Generation Epidemic Intelligence
Chen is creating trustworthy computational tools that leverage artificial intelligence to improve infectious disease forecasting, intervention and surveillance. Her work will help guide public health decision-making related to epidemics and pandemics.



YU MENG
Assistant Professor, Computer Science
AI and Data: Leveraging Imperfect Data
Meng is developing new "structure-aware" methods to help artificial intelligence systems learn effectively even when data is incomplete, noisy or inconsistently labeled. His work will create AI models that extract useful information while filtering out errors.



TIANHAO WANG
Assistant Professor, Computer Science
AI and Cybersecurity: Advancing Differentially Private Data Synthesis
Wang is leveraging synthetic datasets to help organizations gain useful information from sensitive data while protecting people's privacy. His work focuses on differential privacy and risks in artificial intelligence systems.

ACADEMY RECOGNITION

CURRENT AND EMERITUS FACULTY

NATIONAL ACADEMY OF ENGINEERING

MICHAEL L. KING was recently elected to the NAE.

GILDA BARABINO
CRAIG BENSON
JOE CAMPBELL
JOHN DORNING
NICHOLAS GARBER
ANITA JONES
MICHAEL L. KING
EDGAR STARKE
JENNIFER WEST

NATIONAL ACADEMY OF INVENTORS

MIRCEA STAN was recently elected to the NAI.

GILDA BARABINO
CRAIG BENSON
SILVIA BLEMKER
BENTON CALHOUN
JOE CAMPBELL
GEORGE GILLIES
MOOL GUPTA
JOHN HOSSACK
BARRY JOHNSON
CRAIG MEYER
RANDALL MOORMAN
THOMAS SKALAK
MIRCEA STAN
JENNIFER WEST

VIRGINIA ACADEMY OF SCIENCE, ENGINEERING AND MEDICINE

SCOTT ACTON and **MICHAEL L. KING** were recently elected to VASEM.

SCOTT ACTON
JAMES AYLOR
JOE CAMPBELL
JOHN DORNING
NICHOLAS GARBER
JONATHAN GOODALL
ANITA JONES
MICHAEL L. KING
MADHAV MARATHE
JOHN SCULLY
KEVIN SKADRON
JAMES SMITH
JOHN STANKOVIC
EDGAR STARKE
HAYDN WADLEY
JENNIFER WEST
AIDONG ZHANG

A FOCUS ON RESEARCH IMPACT

Leading the Search for the Next Generation of Powerful Magnets

LIQIN KE, MATERIALS SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

UVA Engineering faculty researchers have been awarded a $3 million ARPA-E award to discover new permanent magnets that could outperform today's and bolster U.S. manufacturing leadership.

The project, "Needles in the Materials Haystack (NeedMatH)," is led by

The MAGNITO program seeks transformative solutions by discovering entirely new materials rather than improving what we already have.

— Liqin Ke

LIQIN KE, associate professor of materials science and engineering, while professors Jerry Floro and Lin Zhou serve as UVA's co-principal investigators.

It is a project of the Department of Energy's ARPA-E initiative (Advanced Research Projects Agency-Energy). The project is part of ARPA-E's MAGNITO program, Magnetic Acceleration Generating New Innovations and Tactical Outcomes, an effort to reinvigorate American magnet innovation and strengthen the nation's critical-minerals supply chain. More powerful magnets could enable smaller, lighter and more efficient motors and generators, improving energy productivity and lowering the cost of generating electricity for American industry and transportation.

The team also includes the University of Maryland, UNC Charlotte, George Mason University and the National Institute of Standards and Technology, plus Ames National Laboratory, Princeton University and industry partner Niron Magnetics.

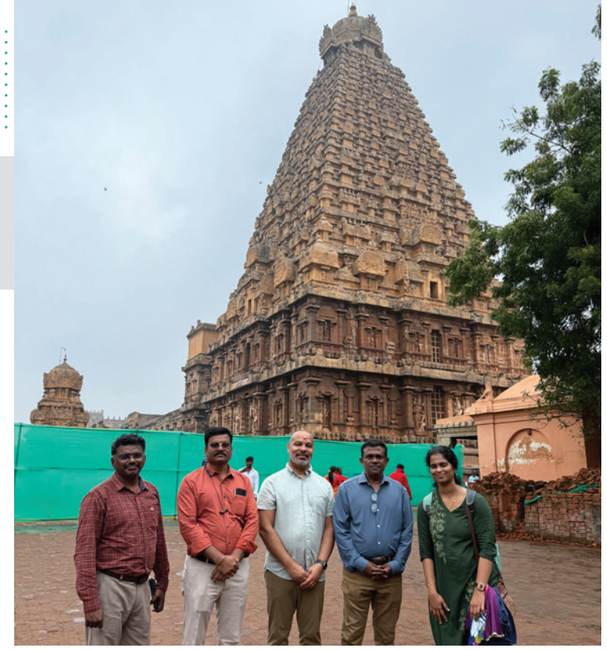
"The MAGNITO program seeks transformative solutions by discovering entirely new materials rather than improving what we already have," Ke said. "Finding a new class of permanent magnets after more than 40 years without a major breakthrough is exactly the kind of hard problem ARPA-E was created to tackle."

The team hopes to find rare-earth compounds that outperform anything on the market today.

According to Beth Opila, chair of UVA Engineering's Department of Materials Science and Engineering, "Magnets are a great example of the central paradigm of materials science and engineering: processing controls structure, which controls the resultant properties.

Students learn about this in our courses, and it's because we actually use the paradigm to frame our research into revolutionary materials."

ARPA-E announced the award as part of a broader $72 million investment in domestic magnet research and critical-mineral supply chains. ■



Bringing Infrastructure Expertise to India

DEVIN HARRIS, CIVIL AND ENVIRONMENTAL ENGINEERING

University of Virginia civil engineering professor **DEVIN HARRIS** spent a month in India on a Fulbright Specialist Program award. Harris, whose research focuses on large-scale civil infrastructure systems, chairs UVA's Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering and was one of about 400 U.S. citizens selected annually to share their expertise abroad.

Harris worked with faculty and students at the National Institute of Technology Tiruchirappalli (Trichy) in India's southernmost state, Tamil Nadu, and immersed himself in the "truly unique academic environment" of NIT Trichy's residential campus, a modern living-learning community not unlike UVA's original model.

Observing centuries-old materials, construction techniques and preservation challenges up close was a powerful reminder of how engineering and heritage conservation can work together.

— Devin Harris

He led workshops on infrastructure assessment and structural health monitoring — work that aligned closely with NIT Trichy's — during a time of rapid development across India. "The challenges we face in the U.S. offer insights into the challenges India can anticipate as its expanding infrastructure ages in years to come," Harris said.

During a trip to the Brihadeeswara Temple, Harris was granted access to areas not typically open to the public — an opportunity that allowed him to see centuries-old structures from a civil engineer's perspective.

"I was able to view these historic structures not only as cultural treasures, but also through the lens of infrastructure assessment," he said. "Observing centuries-old materials, construction techniques and preservation challenges up close was a powerful reminder of how engineering and heritage conservation can work together."

For Harris, the visit reinforced a fundamental idea — engineering principles travel well. The same tools used to monitor bridges, buildings and smart-city systems can help preserve sacred spaces that have stood for centuries.

After his return to the U.S., Harris also stepped into a new leadership role as a member of the University of Virginia Strategic Planning Committee co-chaired by Dean Jennifer West. ■

A FOCUS ON RESEARCH IMPACT

Genesis Mission: Using Artificial Intelligence to Improve Power Grids

Computer science professor Ferdinando Fioretto has been selected to lead a research project for the U.S. Department of Energy's new Genesis Mission, using artificial intelligence to create more resilient, adaptive electric power grids.

The Genesis Mission is a national initiative that aims to double the productivity and impact of American research within a decade. Its first cohort includes 278 projects, which seek to address the nation's most pressing energy, scientific and engineering challenges.

Fioretto's project, "From Static to Adaptive Grids: Autonomous Topology Control at Scale," will develop AI methods that help power grids dynamically adapt to changing conditions, improve resilience and operate more efficiently as demand and energy sources evolve, using the infrastructure that utilities already own. The project is a collaboration with Los Alamos National Laboratory, Siemens Energy and the Orlando Utilities Commission.

Fioretto, who holds an endowed Copenhaver Fellowship, leads UVA's Responsible AI for Science and Engineering (RAISE) group, which builds AI models that obey physical laws, hard constraints and safety requirements. His honors include an NSF CAREER Award and a 2025 Disruptive Ideas Award from the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency.

Fioretto's work builds on the computer science department's broad research strengths, which span artificial intelligence and machine learning, cybersecurity, robotics, software engineering and network science.

"His work shows how AI can transform complex engineering systems in ways that improve infrastructure, strengthen resilience and benefit society," said Sandhya Dwarkadas, professor and chair of the Department of Computer Science.

As a participating researcher, Fioretto will also have access to the Genesis Mission Platform, which combines advanced AI models and high-performance computing resources from DOE's national laboratories and industry partners. That access will boost his team's computing power and speed the path from discovery to real-world use. ■

IEEE: Nikos Sidiropoulos wins Fourier Award, Among Signal Processing's Highest Honors

The technologies that recommend what people watch, keep their cellphones connected and produce medical images have earned a UVA professor one of signal processing's top honors. Nikolaos (Nikos) Sidiropoulos, the Louis T. Rader Professor of Electrical and Computer Engineering, has received the 2027 IEEE Fourier Award for Signal Processing.

IEEE, the world's largest technical professional organization, cited Sidiropoulos' contributions to algebraic signal processing and multidimensional harmonic retrieval — methods that extract useful information from complex, multidimensional data.

Established in 2012 and sponsored by Mitsubishi Electric Research Laboratories, the award honors outstanding contributions to signal processing, which powers technologies from medical imaging and radar to mobile communications.

Sidiropoulos is known for his work on tensor decomposition, which breaks large datasets into simpler parts that reveal hidden structure. His research supports recommender systems, wireless technologies that keep cellphones connected, and medical and environmental imaging.

"What sets Nikos apart is that his theory doesn't stay on the chalkboard," said Scott Acton, chair of the Charles L. Brown Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering. "He builds the math and then shows it works in the real world, from wireless networks to machine learning. Students who work with him learn to do both."

Other honors include the IEEE Signal Processing Society's Claude Shannon-Harry Nyquist Technical Achievement Award, the European Association for Signal Processing's Technical Achievement Award and a UVA Distinguished Researcher Award. He is a fellow of IEEE and EURASIP.

Sidiropoulos joined UVA in 2017 and chaired the department until 2021. He previously taught at the University of Minnesota and the Technical University of Crete.

"I'm honored and humbled to receive the IEEE Fourier Award," Sidiropoulos said. "It's especially rewarding to see how fundamental advances in signal processing can help address real-world challenges." ■

New York Times: Leveraging Biomechanics Research for Athletics and Healthcare

Springbok Analytics, a startup rooted in biomedical engineering research at UVA's School of Engineering and Applied Science, was featured in a New York Times Magazine story on how data is helping athletes play longer and stronger.

Launched with support from UVA's Coulter Center for Translational Research, Springbok focuses on muscle biomechanics, measuring each muscle's size, shape and composition to gauge performance and injury risk.

NBA, NFL, MLS and MLB teams use Springbok's FDA-cleared MuscleView technology, which applies artificial intelligence to MRI scans to help athletes recover from injuries and prevent them.

Springbok joined the NBA's Launchpad incubator in 2023. Its algorithms cut MRI processing time from about 50 hours to one.

Taking many scans over time lets Springbok score each athlete's muscles. Asymmetries "create a predisposition to injury," NBA sports medicine director Dr. John DiFiori told the Times, and big swings in scores can signal it's time to take corrective action.

Springbok's roots, though, are in clinical care. It began with a 2009 proposal by Silvia Blemker, Craig Meyer, Joe Hart and Mark Abel for an MRI tool to help surgeons treat children with cerebral palsy.

"Our goal is to help anyone with musculoskeletal issues and those with disorders like cerebral palsy and FSHD," said Blemker, a UVA biomedical engineering professor and Springbok co-founder. FSHD, or facioscapulohumeral muscular dystrophy, is a common, debilitating muscle disease. ■

ENTREPRENEURSHIP
AND INNOVATION PARTNERSHIPS

UVA Engineering fosters a thriving entrepreneurial community that translates research — and big ideas — into real-world ventures.

VentureForward student founders Theodore Vaughan, Akshita Tiwari and Aaditya Kotadia.

FACULTY VENTURES

Examples Include:

- Cerillo
- CytoRecovery
- Dominion MicroProbes
- Everactive
- Laser Thermal
- Luminosity Wearables
- Lytos Technologies
- MadiDrop
- Mission Secure
- Rivanna Medical
- Springbok Analytics
- Vasarya Therapeutics
- WiSights Lab

STUDENT AND ALUMNI VENTURES

Examples Include:

- AgroSpheres
- Alfie Health
- Babylon Micro-Farms
- Beanstalk
- Cambrient AI
- Cardinal
- Cognition
- Contraline
- Dream
- Haladir
- Hardshell
- HemoSonics
- Hobski
- HYBRD
- Kymanox
- Logical
- Mantle
- Nanochon
- Nuro
- Pangolin
- qMe
- Reddit
- Redside Custom Tools
- Valor Biomechanics

ENTREPRENEURIAL VENTURES

AgroSpheres

Started by biomedical engineering undergraduates, this alumni biotech company offers nature-based alternatives to chemical pesticides, now produced at its Albemarle County plant, and was named a Time top GreenTech company.

Dream

Founded by 2026 UVA Engineering computer science graduates, Dream joined Y Combinator's highly selective summer 2026 cohort. The company's AI-powered cameras automatically detect damage to vehicles, equipment and other high-value assets.

Hardshell

Founded by two systems engineers with ties to UVA Engineering and Darden, this AI-security startup grew through the i.Lab Incubator, raised $1.1 million in pre-seed funding, and was a 2026 Galant Challenge finalist.

Laser Thermal

The faculty-founded materials testing company has commercialized a device for ultra-precise thermal property measurements essential for next-generation semiconductor design.

Governor Abigail Spanberger celebrates the opening of AgroSpheres' new Albemarle County facility

EDUCATION AND SUPPORT

UVA Engineering faculty, student and alumni founders find support within the school, across UVA and the community, and beyond. The school has one of the most progressive entrepreneurial environments among R1 top-tier research universities.

VentureForward

UVA Engineering's VentureForward program fosters hands-on entrepreneurial experiences for engineering students, faculty and staff through microgrants, mentorship and training. The program started in 2024 and has funded more than 40 projects. Open to ideas at any stage, VentureForward awards up to $1,000 to new teams and up to $2,500 to returning teams.

Coulter Center

UVA's Wallace H. Coulter Center for Translational Research invests over $1 million annually in projects addressing unmet clinical needs. Founded in 2006 and powered by a $42 million endowment, the Center connects engineers, clinicians, and industry partners to advance biomedical innovation, develop commercially viable medical products, and prepare the next generation of innovators through experiential learning, industry engagement, and translational skill development.

KEEN

In 2026, UVA Engineering joined the Kern Entrepreneurial Engineering Network (KEEN), a nationwide partnership of 70 colleges and universities committed to graduating engineers with an entrepreneurial mindset. Guided by KEEN's 3Cs — curiosity, connections and creating value — UVA Engineering is expanding entrepreneurial learning across its curriculum.

University and Community Partners

In partnership with UVA School of Medicine and Darden and McIntire business schools, UVA Engineering sparks entrepreneurial collaboration across disciplines. Students can tap into i.Lab and The Foundry while faculty work with UVA Licensing & Ventures Group, Seed Fund and Enterprise Studio. Local partners including the 434 Accelerator, CAV Angels, Cville Biohub and Virginia Innovation Partnership Corporation extend the network.

I care deeply about protecting our environment, so we have to think about food production that is sustainable and safe.
— Bryan Berger

BRYAN BERGER NAMED UVA'S 2025 INNOVATOR OF THE YEAR

UVA Engineering's Bryan Berger was named the 2025 Edlich-Henderson Innovator of the Year by the UVA Licensing & Ventures Group. It is the highest honor bestowed on UVA innovators, dating back to 1992.

Berger, a professor of chemical engineering and biomedical engineering, invented the protein-based biotechnologies behind his startup, Lytos Technologies. Founded in 2018, the company works to make food safer through sustainable alternatives that also protect soil and water.

Berger is a self-described biotech enthusiast whose deep commitment to public health, food safety, and environmental protection has led from his research in the engineering lab to the launch of Lytos. His groundbreaking research in protein engineering and synthetic biology has attracted national recognition, competitive grants and industry partnerships that elevate UVA's reputation in biotechnology and sustainability.

Dean Jennifer West praised Berger for excelling as both a researcher and an entrepreneur — a rare combination. Innovators of the Year, she said, "take what they've done in the lab and use those results to make the world a better place."

In 2019, with LVG's help, Lytos licensed Berger's patented biofungicide technology, which protects crops and safeguards public health. That technology, along with other inventions from his UVA Engineering lab, detects and removes foodborne pathogens, protects animal health and reduces food spoilage — drawing interest from crop protection companies and from growers of apples, cider and wine. Last summer, Lytos moved into a new 4,000-square-foot R&D and manufacturing space in Waynesboro.

"I'm truly honored," Berger said. "It has been a challenging, rewarding journey to get Lytos to this point. I care deeply about protecting our environment, so we have to think about food production that is sustainable and safe. With a projected 9 billion people to feed by 2050, this is a major challenge." ■

UVA Chief Innovation Officer Paul Cherukuri, Dean Jennifer West, LVG Executive Director Richard Chylla, Bryan Berger, Vice President for Research Lori McMahon

Collin Togher and Armaan Chakrabarti

UVA COMPUTER SCIENCE STUDENTS WIN ENTREPRENEURSHIP CUP WITH AI CYBERSECURITY STARTUP

University of Virginia computer science students and childhood friends Armaan Chakrabarti and Collin Togher won UVA's Entrepreneurship Cup, a competition highlighting student startup ideas with real-world impact.

Their company, Cambrient AI, built a cybersecurity tool that helps small businesses and IT providers protect their email systems. Email remains a common entry point for cyberattacks, and Cambrient uses artificial intelligence to flag suspicious messages, links and attachments in real time.

Cambrient's system is designed to be user-friendly. It integrates with Microsoft 365 and Google Workspace with no complex setup and explains threats clearly so users can respond quickly.

The founders received seed funding, mentorship and training from UVA Engineering's VentureForward program.

"Great ventures do not start big," said David Chen, UVA Engineering's assistant dean for entrepreneurship and innovation partnerships. "Armaan and Collin, with patience, persistence and a little nudge from VentureForward, are building something unique and special."

This summer, Cambrient AI joined the Batten Institute's i.Lab Incubator, a 10-week program for early-stage UVA ventures. Chakrabarti pitched at Demo Night in the Rotunda in August.

The startup has also earned key awards at ChannelPro DEFEND and ASCII Edge, establishing it as an up-and-coming innovator in agentic email security. ■

GLOBAL LAB TECHNOLOGY LEADER HAMILTON ACQUIRES UVA SPIN-OFF CERILLO

Global life sciences company Hamilton has acquired Charlottesville-based UVA Engineering spin-off Cerillo to strengthen its instrument and automation lineup and help it deliver solutions for modern laboratory workflows.

Cerillo was founded in 2016 by UVA biomedical engineering professor Jason Papin, professor emeritus Erik Hewlett and alumnus Kevin Seitter.

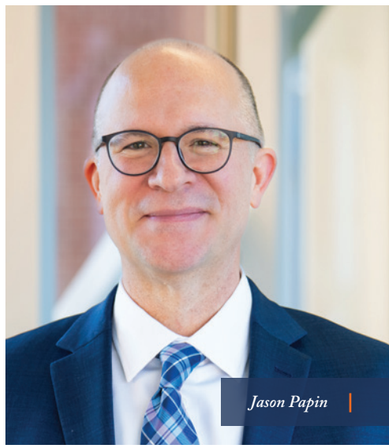
Papin called the acquisition "a really big win for translational efforts."

Cerillo invented a portable microplate reader that lets researchers run experiments in incubators, anaerobic chambers or the field, speeding the work behind new drugs, diagnostics and other bio-based products.

Frustrated by bulky, restrictive lab equipment, Papin, Seitter and Paul Jensen prototyped the first reader — built for ease and accuracy — with funding from UVA's Wallace H. Coulter Center for Translational Research. Cerillo has since added two more readers, with wireless real-time data streaming and the industry's first standardized system for studying how microbial populations interact.

Joining Hamilton gives Cerillo "more resources to make great laboratory tools that make researchers' work easier, faster and more productive," said Seitter, now the company's chief technology officer.

Cerillo will expand globally while keeping its Charlottesville location, where it has employed UVA Engineering graduates and student interns. ■



Jason Papin

INDUSTRY ENGAGEMENT

40CORE: A NEW MODEL FOR INDUSTRY ENGAGEMENT

40Core, UVA Engineering's Industry Engagement program, provides corporate partners with access to top engineering students, cutting-edge research, and new ideas ready for the marketplace. 40Core is building a sustainable cohort of more than 50 partners to date including Dell, Leidos, Lenovo, Microsoft, Northrop Grumman, Rolls-Royce, and more.

Rolls-Royce Employer Spotlight

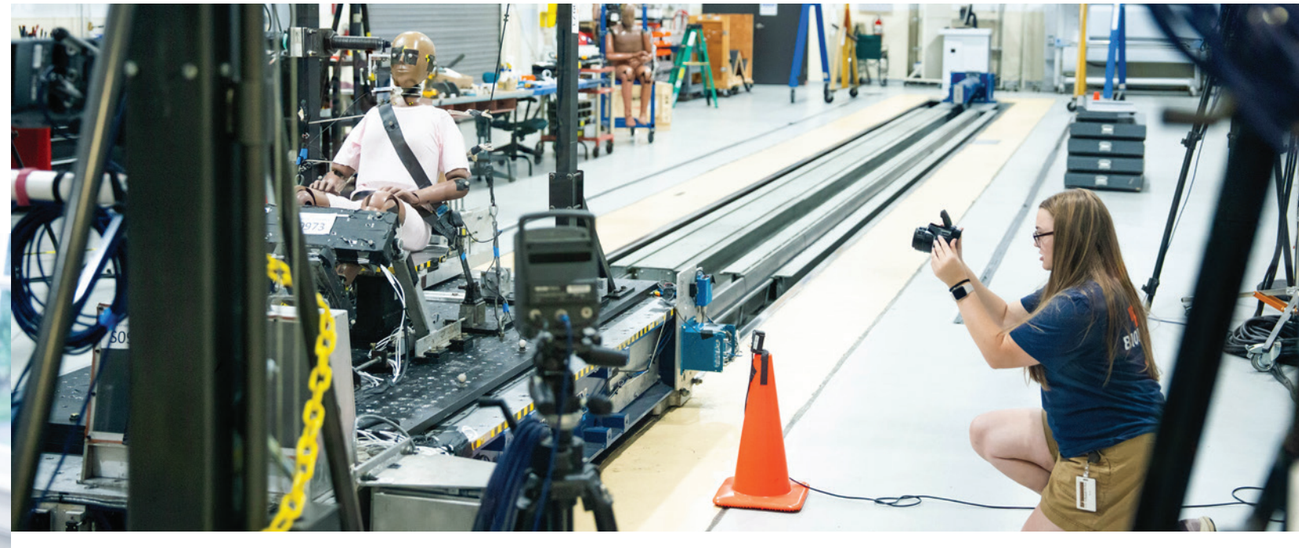
40CORE EMPLOYER SPOTLIGHTS

Industry partners including Booz Allen Hamilton, Cisco, Dominion Energy, Google, Rolls-Royce and others participated in Employer Spotlight days, giving students insight into life as a working engineer and internship and job opportunities. Employer Spotlight companies also met with faculty and school leaders about opportunities for research and commercialization partnerships.

PARTNERSHIP WITH CAPITAL ONE ACCELERATES AI RESEARCH AND INVESTS IN STUDENTS

UVA Engineering announced a $4.5 million partnership with Capital One to help faculty and students push the frontiers of artificial intelligence and prepare to lead in an AI-driven world. Capital One's investment will fund the creation of the Capital One AI Research Neighborhood in UVA Engineering's new Whitehead Road Engineering Academic Building, which will bring together more than 50 researchers in machine learning, data analytics, behavioral design and cyber systems working at the leading edge of AI.

The investment also provided the foundation for the Capital One Ph.D. Fellowship Awards, which help the school's most promising Ph.D. students accelerate their drive for AI discovery. The 2026-2027 Capital One Ph.D. Fellows include Zhepei Wei, a Ph.D. student in the Department of Computer Science, and Zhenyu Lei, a Ph.D. student in the Charles L. Brown Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering. ■



FORBES FEATURES UVA-TOYOTA BIOMECHANICS RESEARCH PARTNERSHIP

UVA Engineering's Center for Applied Biomechanics (CAB) has long helped automakers use virtual human body models to predict and prevent crash injuries, as Forbes recently reported.

Since 2011, the center has collaborated with Toyota's Collaborative Safety Research Center, or CSRC, on studies using THUMS, software simulating body types and positions.

When reclined-seating simulations raised questions about lap belts and the pelvis, the UVA team took the problem into the lab, said Jason R. Kerrigan, Commonwealth Professor of mechanical and aerospace engineering and the center's director.

Their findings led to over 900 experiments and informed future THUMS versions.

Alumnus Zhaonan Sun is now a Toyota CSRC principal scientist studying how the shapes of SUVs and pickup trucks affect pedestrian injuries. He earned his Ph.D. in mechanical engineering at UVA under Kerrigan.

"I wouldn't say the work at the university is the tip of the iceberg. I would say it's half of the iceberg," Sun said. "And now it's great to see the other half — how we leverage the results to talk to our regulators, rating agencies, and safety stakeholders."

UVA CAB's research has also traced women's higher ankle injury rates in some crashes to tibias that generally fracture more easily. Now CSRC's newest projects include three with UVA, centering on ankle injuries, spine injuries and virtual testing. ■

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Emerging Engineers

UVA Engineering Open House

UVA Engineering creates meaningful connections with the Charlottesville region and beyond, building pathways to engineering education for students at every level and inspiring the next generation of problem-solvers.

UVA Engineering Open House welcomes prospective students, families and community members for a day of hands-on demonstrations, lab tours and conversations with current students and faculty. It offers an inside look at the collaborative culture that makes a UVA Engineering education distinctive.

Engineering Futures Day brings high school students from across Virginia to Grounds to experience life as a UVA Engineering student. Participants collaborate on design activities, explore engineering majors, tour labs and residence halls, and hear from speakers as they consider a future in STEM.

Emerging Engineers, the school's flagship high school outreach initiative, is a free, week-long summer program.

EMERGING ENGINEERS PROGRAM GIVES HIGH SCHOOL STUDENTS GLIMPSE INTO LIFE AS AN ENGINEER

This summer, 180 high school students participated in UVA Engineering's Emerging Engineers program, a free, week-long summer day camp.

The program aims to help students who may not see themselves as engineers discover a new path, said Meara Habashi, UVA Engineering's Associate Dean for Community, Opportunity and Engagement.

"We want these students to figure out what an engineer does, how an engineer thinks, and where can they fit in," Habashi said.

What began as a single biomedical engineering program has tripled in size, drawing record applications and participants this year. Students can choose from six tracks: biomedical, materials science, systems, mechanical, aerospace and chemical engineering.

Each track centers on a real-world project that solves problems for others. Students built disaster-ready water filters from cotton, pebbles and sand, crash-tested popsicle-stick vehicles carrying an egg "passenger," and designed a music festival that limits the spread of contagious viruses like COVID-19. At week's end, they presented their designs at the Emerging Engineers Expo.

"The personal connection developed through solving problems for others often makes engineering feel more accessible," said Hannah Moore, Associate Director of the Wallace H. Coulter Center for Translational Research and the program's first coordinator.

Habashi hopes to add a residential option for students across the Commonwealth and the nation. "We want students to get the full Emerging Engineers experience and see that, 'Hey, I can belong here,'" she said.

We want these students to figure out what an engineer does, how an engineer thinks, and where can they fit in.

— Meara Habashi

ALUMNI ENGAGEMENT

UVA Engineering alumni represent a powerful force for innovation and leadership. Whether leading Fortune 500 companies, founding groundbreaking startups, spearheading research initiatives, shaping public policy or serving on UVA Engineering boards, members of the school's extensive alumni network exemplify the impact of Engineering for the Greater Good.

UVA ENGINEERING HONORS ALUMNI EXCELLENCE

UVA Engineering presents Achievement Awards that honor distinguished members of its community at the annual Thornton Society Dinner, recognizing alumni who have made significant contributions to the school, the community, and the professional world.

2025 Distinguished Alumni Career Award
LINWOOD A. LACY JR.

Chip Lacy (B.S. Chemical Engineering, UVA, 1967; M.B.A. Darden, 1969) served as CEO of Ingram Micro, Ingram Industries, and Micro Warehouse, co-founded 4sure.com, and has chaired boards of major corporations. At UVA, Chip and his wife Connie established Lacy Hall and Lacy Lab, giving students space to design, build, and test their own work.

2025 Distinguished Alumni Engineering Award
STEVE HUFFMAN

Steve Huffman (B.S. Computer Science, 2005) co-founded Reddit, building the "front page of the internet" into one of the world's most visited websites. After founding Hipmunk, he returned as CEO in 2015, driving the growth behind Reddit's 2024 IPO. He mentors entrepreneurs and serves on the Anti-Defamation League's Tech Advisory Board.

2025 Outstanding Young Engineering Graduate Award
ROBERT A. GOLDEN

Robert Golden (Ph.D. Materials Science and Engineering, 2017) leads development of ceramic matrix composite coatings and thermal barrier technologies for net-zero propulsion at Rolls-Royce. As University Technology Center Coordinator, he strengthens the UVA–Rolls-Royce partnership, mentors graduate students, and supports design projects.

Dean Jennifer West and Linwood A. Lacy Jr.

ALUMNI BY THE NUMBERS

33,801
UVA Engineering Alumni

ALUMNI INVEST IN FUTURE ENGINEERING LEADERS

MANY ALUMNI MAINTAIN STRONG CONNECTIONS TO THE SCHOOL AND OPEN DOORS FOR TODAY'S STUDENTS, REFLECTING THE ENDURING BONDS FORGED ON ENGINEER'S WAY.

This winter at the Engineering Student Council's Dome Dinner in the Rotunda, **MISSY CUMMINGS** (Ph.D., Systems Engineering, 2004) described her experiences as one of the Navy's first female fighter pilots and her AI research.

The Spring 2026 Brenton S. Halsey Distinguished Visiting Professor, **TODD KENNEDY** (B.S., Chemical Engineering, 1996), executive vice president at Capital One, taught a course on human values in technical business.

LAUREN AUGUSTINE (B.S., Applied Mathematics and Systems Engineering, 1991), executive director of the National Academies' Gulf Research Program, led a fireside chat in the Link Lab.

ANNE AUNINS (B.S., Chemical Engineering, 1985), spoke at the annual Rodman Scholars Banquet.

GREG OLSEN (Ph.D., Materials Science and Engineering, 1971) shared his path as an entrepreneur, astronaut and venture capitalist.

STEVE HUFFMAN (B.S., Computer Science, 2005), Reddit co-founder and CEO, spoke to students about entrepreneurship and AI and connected with student founders at a Demo Party.

ART FULLER (B.S., Electrical Engineering, 1986) spoke at the Order of the Engineer ceremony, where graduates pledged to make ethical engineering decisions.

NATIONAL ACADEMY OF ENGINEERING

MICHAEL L. KING, PH.D.

Michael L. King, an alumnus and professor of practice in chemical engineering, was recognized for leadership in commercializing, manufacturing and supplying vaccines and pharmaceuticals.

King spent more than 30 years in Merck's research and manufacturing divisions, developing and commercializing numerous pharmaceuticals and vaccines. During the COVID-19 pandemic, he worked with the Gates Foundation and COVAX to ensure equitable global vaccine access. He is vice chair of the Scientific Advisory Committee of the Coalition for Epidemic Preparedness Innovations (CEPI), which leads rapid responses to disease outbreaks.

King joined UVA in 2007 as the Brenton S. Halsey Distinguished Visiting Professor and was named professor of practice in 2013.

He earned a bachelor's degree from Virginia Tech in 1974, a master's in chemical engineering from UVA in 1976 and a Ph.D. from the University of Delaware in 1980.

ANNE AUNINS, PH.D.

Anne Aunins, a chemical engineering alumna, was recognized for leadership in bioprocess engineering and biopharmaceutical manufacturing. With a career dedicated to translating engineering advances into scalable, life-changing technologies, she has advanced therapies that improve health outcomes worldwide.

Aunins joined Merck in 1991, where she helped develop vaccines as well as drugs for asthma, migraines and rare diseases. She moved to Moderna mid-pandemic to lead its Zika vaccine program and became program leader for its COVID-19 vaccine program, overseeing regulatory approval, booster strategies and variant response, helping shape one of the most consequential public health efforts in recent history.

A Rodman Scholar, she earned a bachelor's degree in chemical engineering from UVA in 1985 and a Ph.D. from MIT in 1991. Aunins also serves on the UVA Engineering Foundation Board of Trustees.

Helping Lenovo Build a Human-Centered World Cup Experience

UVA Engineering alumnus Matthew Geary and his team at technology company Lenovo were facing a big task.

As Official Technology Partner of FIFA World Cup 2026, Lenovo took on one of FIFA's biggest operational challenges: critical data scattered across disparate systems, with no time to hunt for it during the world's largest sporting event.

Geary, director of user research and insights at Lenovo, had to answer one question: "How can we bring this information together to enable faster, better decisions while keeping it human-centered?"

The answer: the Intelligent Command Center, a centralized real-time operations platform that "gives FIFA a holistic, live view of everything happening across the tournament," according to Lenovo. AI integration helps surface emerging issues and risks earlier.

They also created an 85-inch, interactive "Wall of Joy," which used AI integration to capture the global FIFA World Cup spirit by curating social media posts to help FIFA decision-makers and employees better connect with the fan experience.

"We have great products and know how to build software, and FIFA knows how to run a soccer tournament," Geary said. "So it's about partnering. We wanted to build a platform that made people say, 'Wow, this experience was built for me.'"

Geary credits his time at UVA Engineering, where he earned a bachelor's degree in biomedical engineering and economics in 2006.

"My class was the first full year of the biomedical engineering undergraduate program," he said. "I took mechanical, electrical and computer engineering classes and applied them to biological systems. It set me up for this role — understanding the interconnectedness of many different systems, which is what I do now." ■

Encouraging Student Founders to Embrace Opportunity

Reddit co-founder and CEO Steve Huffman spoke with UVA Engineering students this winter about entrepreneurship and the fast-changing world of artificial intelligence, including the role he sees for Reddit in the age of AI. "While AI summarizes and sanitizes the rest of the internet, Reddit is not AI. Reddit is for humans," Huffman told UVA Engineering students.

Still, he sees Reddit and AI platforms helping each other. Reddit works with OpenAI and Google, he said, on a simple premise: "We'll help you build your product if you help ours work better."

"When I don't want the AI version, when I want the messy version, I go to Reddit. I think both can exist."

To student founders who voiced fear about missing the AI wave, he offered encouragement: there will always be another innovation wave coming. "The important thing is to stay in the game. Show up even though you're uncomfortable. Just do the thing and eventually things go your way."

During his visit, Huffman also met with faculty and with student founders at a Demo Party hosted by VentureForward, UVA Engineering's seed-funding and mentorship program.

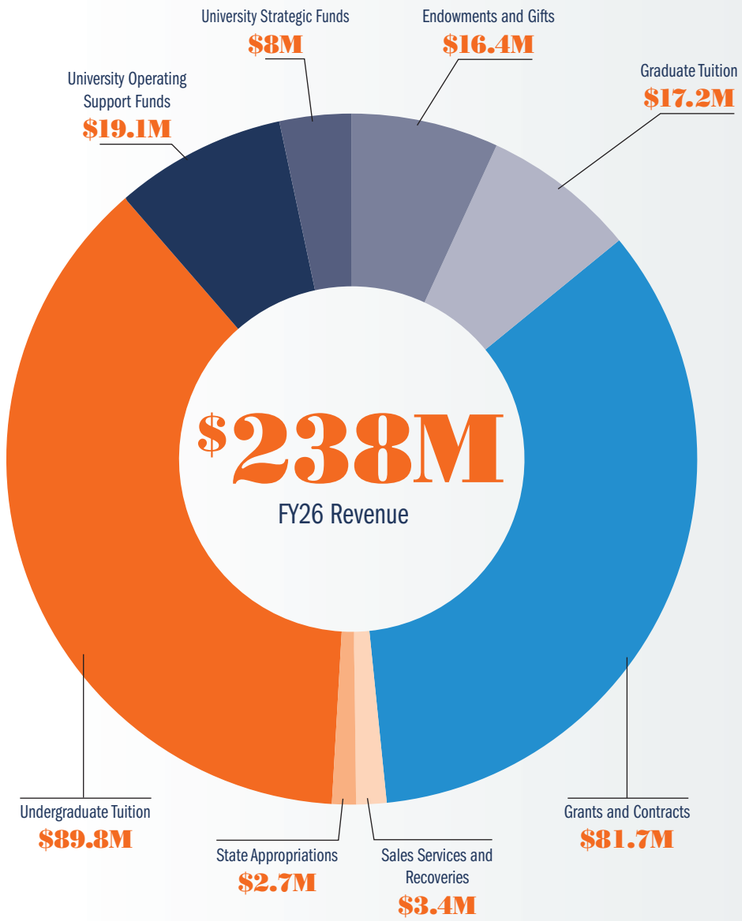
Huffman co-founded Reddit in 2005 and returned to UVA Engineering to accept the 2025 Distinguished Alumni Engineering Award.

Once he entered the working world and met graduates of other schools, Huffman said, he came to appreciate that UVA Engineering had "a really nice balance between the theoretical and the practical." Computer science, he said, reflects that balance, with math on one end and, on the other, "you're just building stuff. It's Legos. Both, I think, are really important and feed on each other." ■

SCHOOL OPERATIONS

The UVA School of Engineering and Applied Science pairs continued revenue growth with strong fiscal stewardship, positioning the school to meet its short-term goals and advance its long-term aspirations.

BY THE NUMBERS



FY26 revenue totaled **$238 MILLION**, with continued growth in tuition, endowments and gifts.

FACULTY AND STAFF

The school's faculty and staff community includes **268 FACULTY**: 192 tenured and tenure-track (T3) and 76 academic general faculty (AGF). It also includes **173 STAFF** (A&P, classified and university) and **73 PROFESSIONAL RESEARCH STAFF** (PRS).

RESEARCH ENTERPRISE

Despite ongoing disruptions from federal sponsors, UVA Engineering's FY26 research momentum remained strong. Faculty submitted a record-breaking 686 new research proposals, reflecting the school's commitment to growing its research enterprise.

UNIVERSITY LEADERSHIP

UVA STRATEGIC PLANNING COMMITTEE

DEAN JENNIFER L. WEST was appointed by UVA President Scott Beardsley to co-chair the University's strategic planning committee, bringing UVA Engineering's perspective to the University's next strategic plan.

Professor **DEVIN HARRIS**, chair of the Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering, also represents UVA Engineering on the committee.

The committee will build on community input to chart the University's future in education, research, health care and public service.

UVA FACULTY SENATE

The UVA Faculty Senate is chaired by **AARON BLOOMFIELD**, professor of computer science, School of Engineering and Applied Science.

UVA STAFF SENATE

The UVA Staff Senate is co-chaired by **LIZZIE BATMAN**, Dean's Office, School of Engineering and Applied Science.

PHILANTHROPY

ENGINEERING *for the* GREATER GOOD, POWERED BY PHILANTHROPY

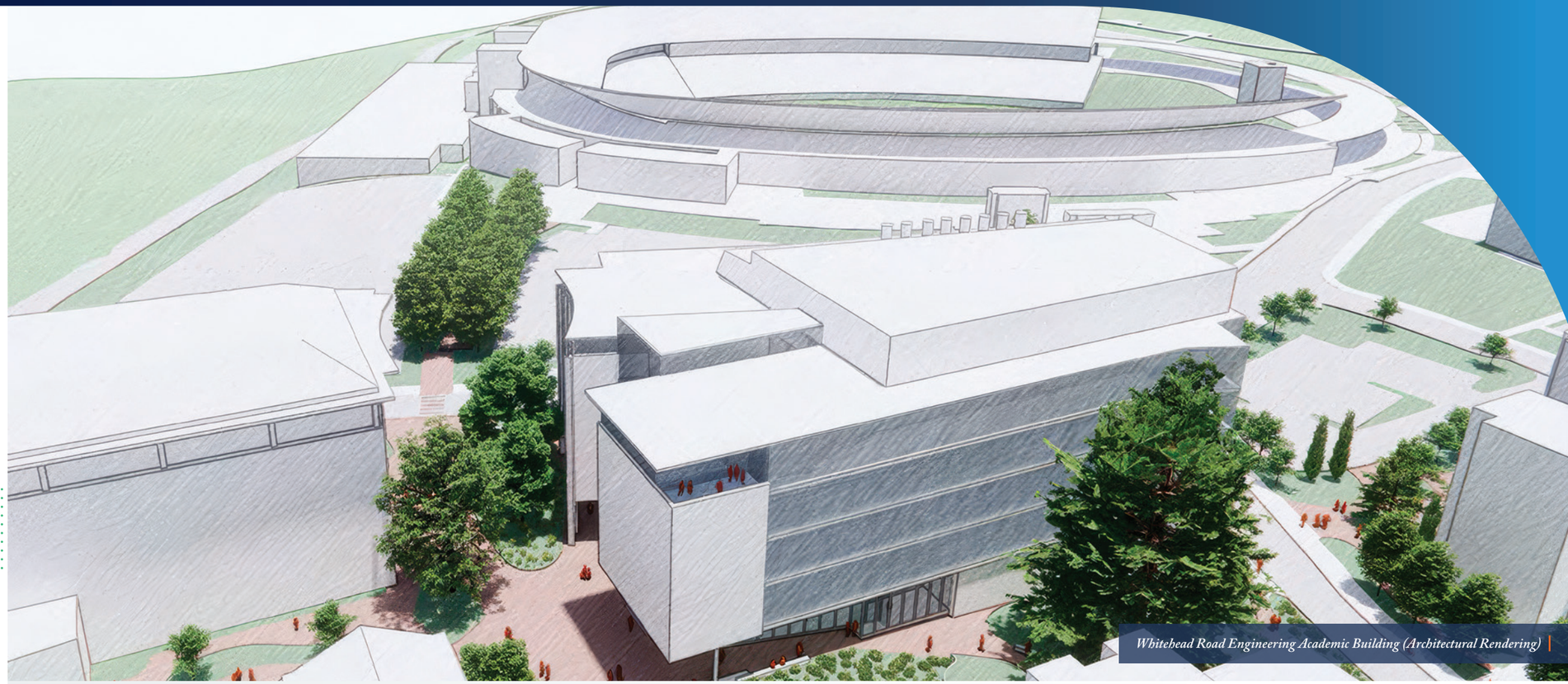
UVA Engineering's Office of Advancement, working in partnership with UVA External Relations and the UVA Engineering Foundation, engage donors in advancing the school's mission of Engineering for the Greater Good. Philanthropy helps enrich the undergraduate experience, strengthen graduate education, and accelerate research discoveries. In fiscal year 2026, more than 4,000 donors contributed $27.4 million to fuel the school's mission.

BY THE NUMBERS

4,060
FY26 Donors

$27.4M
FY26 Gifts Raised

$1.7M
FY26 Thornton Society Leadership Giving



Whitehead Road Engineering Academic Building (Architectural Rendering)

FOUR PRIORITIES, ONE MISSION

Four core philanthropic priorities advance the mission: student enrichment and opportunity, experiential learning and entrepreneurship, research and impact, and infrastructure, including a new building to meet growing enrollment and research needs.

Student Enrichment and Opportunity

Philanthropy helps the school educate and empower students, preparing them for successful careers and impactful lives. Gifts fund merit scholarships, student support programs, and enrichment opportunities.

Whitehead Road Engineering Academic Building

The new building will add needed infrastructure and create a hub for innovation, discovery and learning that meets growing student enrollment and research needs. Students will gain enhanced hands-on learning spaces and faculty will gain leading-edge resources for collaborative research. The 230,000-square-foot building will bring researchers together across disciplines to advance work in AI, health, energy and environmental resilience.

Research and Impact

UVA Engineering's faculty and students pursue high-impact research across engineering and technology disciplines. Gifts endow professorships for leading researchers, fund graduate fellowships for emerging talent, and expand research opportunities for undergraduates.

Experiential Learning and Entrepreneurship

Experiential learning programs let students apply classroom knowledge to real-world challenges, fostering critical thinking, creativity, and problem-solving skills. Gifts strengthen student clubs and leadership opportunities, fund conference travel and activities, and fuel the VentureForward entrepreneurship initiative.

PHILANTHROPY FUELS MOMENTUM FOR UVA ENGINEERING'S NEXT ACADEMIC BUILDING

Kitty O'Brien Joyner

A $5 million investment from anonymous donors is among the gifts advancing the Whitehead Road Engineering Academic Building, which will add critical space and resources for the growing school.

The $5 million commitment comes at an important juncture for UVA Engineering, helping the school prepare for its next chapter of Engineering for the Greater Good.

"This extraordinary gift will benefit our community today and in years to come," said Jennifer West, dean of UVA's School of Engineering and Applied Science. "The building project is critical to the University's ambitions for achieving research preeminence. We thank these generous donors for enabling our growth as a research institution."

The 230,000-square-foot, student-centric building on Engineer's Way will be organized around collaborative "research neighborhoods" tackling challenges in AI, health, energy, and environmental resilience. Its state-of-the-art labs will foster collaboration within Engineering and across Grounds. The building will house more than 50 faculty and include student design and maker spaces, an entrepreneurship suite, and an outdoor courtyard.

The anonymous gift will fund the building's 300-seat auditorium, to be named at the donors' request for UVA Engineering's first female graduate, Kitty O'Brien Joyner.

"Kitty O'Brien Joyner was a pathbreaking engineer at UVA and beyond," said West. "Her work had significant impact on advanced avionics and hypersonics, and her strength of character continues to inspire us today."

In 1937, Kitty O'Brien lobbied to join UVA's all-male School of Engineering. She earned her bachelor's degree in 1939, decades before full co-education. She became the first woman engineer at the National Advisory Committee for Aeronautics, the federal agency that became NASA. She rose to branch head over more than 30 years of service.

The building project will combine philanthropic and state support, and significant gifts are driving momentum for this priority. In addition to this gift, the project has received major commitments from more than two dozen donors and fundraising continues this year. ■

A COMMUNITY *of* SUPPORTERS

LEADERSHIP GIVING

The Thornton Society is UVA Engineering's leadership giving community, recognizing loyal supporters who make cumulative annual unrestricted gifts to the school or its departments. These flexible gifts make an immediate impact, empowering UVA Engineering to tackle society's most complex challenges. In fiscal year 2026, more than 390 Thornton Society donors contributed more than $1.7 million in leadership giving toward the school's top priorities.

ANNUAL GIVING

Each year, generous supporters make gifts of all sizes to the UVA Engineering Annual Fund. In fiscal year 2026, 3,876 donors contributed just over $2.1 million to the school and its academic departments through annual giving. The March 2026 Giving Day, a cornerstone of annual giving, raised $155,596 from 331 donors.

PLANNED GIVING

Donors who make planned gifts become members of UVA Engineering's Aylor Society and UVA's Cornerstone Society. These gifts include lifetime annuities, estate gifts and other financial planning arrangements that benefit both donors and the school. Realized bequests and future gifts can transform the school, funding new endowments, research programs, professorships, scholarships, and emerging priorities.

DEAN and LEADERSHIP

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JENNIFER L. WEST

Dean of Engineering

Saunders Family Professor of Engineering

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UNIVERSITY OF VIRGINIA
ENGINEERING FOUNDATION

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